derprepared, he headed to The Drama Book Shop to acquaint himself with his works. *Letters of Suresh* was one of the buys. "One of the indicators [of whether I should do a play] is how long it stays with me. If it keeps coming back and you feel like re-reading it, I must adapt it," says Khan.

layered, complex, dense yet so accessible and compelling because it explores so many themes at the same time," he adds.

Like Khan's other works, *Letters of Suresh* also relies on audience participation albeit of a different kind compared to his musicals—"they need to

WITH *LETTERS OF SURESH*, FEROZ ABBAS KHAN, BEST KNOWN FOR HIS BIG MUSICALS, TAKES THE MINIMALIST ROUTE, EMPHASISING ON THE ART OF LISTENING

The work sees Suresh, an origami wunderkind based in the US, read out letters he's written to Father Hashimoto, a priest based in Nagasaki. "It's so

link a lot of things", says Khan. The adaptation wasn't entirely easy for Khan either. "Only when I know it will be difficult to do, will I do it," he says. With this play, Khan is also evoking the lost art of letter writing. "When you put pen

to paper, the little pause allows reflection," he says, adding how instant communication has made us lose that ability. "With letters you are able to express yourself much better."

The stage is how Khan has been expressing himself for four decades now, first as an actor and then as director. He credits the late Jennifer Kendal, founder of Prithvi Theatre and wife of late actor Shashi Kapoor, as an instrumental figure in his life. "I would have been a CA or a manager if not for Jennifer and Prithvi," he says. Khan was part of the founding team of the Prithvi Theatre Festival and later served as its artistic director after Kendal's demise. These days though Khan is better known for being a mentor and adviser to NMACC.

What's impressive is that at an age when most

are preparing to hang up their boots, Khan, 65, is going through one of his most productive phases. In addition to *Letters of Suresh*, he has two more scripts waiting, with at least one looking to premiere this year. And no it's not a great Indian musical but like *Letters of Suresh* one where the text takes precedence. "[The] journey has to be about going into unchartered territories...it's the only way you grow," he says. Success, for Khan, cannot come at the cost of stagnation. Musicals for now take a backseat, but the creator in him is still raring to go. Says Khan, "I haven't felt so passionate, so able to do the work that I want to. I'd like to die with my boots on, in a rehearsal room or on the stage." Trust Khan to be dramatic even in imagining the unimaginable. ■

–Suhani Singh



Rapper and actor **SlowCheeta, aka Chaitnya Sharma,** conscioulsy keeps his two careers separate

anthem '90's *ke Ladke*', which celebrates achieving what you set out to do. On outro '*Chai Biskoot*', he reflects on "what just happened".

As with most rappers, identity is a recurring theme in SlowCheeta's work. In his case, it's something he's been grappling with since he was a child, he says. His first name Chaitnya is spelt without the second 'a' because an uncle suggested his parents remove it for numerological reasons. Similarly, his performance name is written without the 'h' that ends "cheetah". "I've spent my life correcting people [about my name]," he says. "So when I started writing as 'Cheeta', I would leave out the 'h' [perhaps] as a subconscious way [to say], this is my unique identity."

His upper-middle class background also makes him stand out among his peers. The rapper says he named his EP *Scene Mein Bawaal* (Commotion in the Scene) to let people know that "I've come here to disrupt everything". And that despite his occasional hiatuses, he's "not going anywhere". ■

–Amit Gurbaxani